

Reading

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Good Manners Around the World

Before you read

- Think about a time you visited a new place or met people from a different background. What customs surprised you?
- What does the word 'etiquette' mean to you?

Every culture in the world has its own set of unwritten rules about polite behaviour. These rules, often called social norms or etiquette, guide how people greet each other, eat together, and show respect. Although the details are different, most cultures share the same basic values: honesty, kindness, and respect for others.

In many Western countries, a firm handshake and direct eye contact are seen as signs of confidence and respect. In parts of East Asia, a slight bow is more common, and it is considered impolite to shake hands too firmly. In some Middle Eastern and South Asian cultures, taking off your shoes before entering someone's home is both a custom and a sign of courtesy toward the host.

Table manners also vary widely. In some countries, finishing every bite on your plate shows gratitude to the cook. In others, leaving a little food behind is a polite way of showing that you have had enough. Neither habit is right or wrong on its own — both are simply different expressions of the same value: respect.

Learning about another culture's customs is not just useful for travellers. It also teaches tolerance and open-mindedness. When we understand why people behave the way they do, we are less likely to judge them unfairly. A truly polite person is not only someone who follows their own culture's rules but also someone who respects other people's norms, even when those norms are unfamiliar.

So the next time you meet someone from a different background, try to notice — and appreciate — both the differences and the shared values underneath them.

1. According to the text, what do most cultures share, despite different customs?
 - a. The same table manners
 - b. The same greeting style
 - c. Basic values like honesty, kindness and respect
 - d. The same rules about shoes
2. In the text, what is considered impolite in parts of East Asia?
 - a. Bowing slightly
 - b. Shaking hands too firmly
 - c. Removing your shoes
 - d. Finishing your food
3. In some Middle Eastern and South Asian cultures, taking off your _____ before entering a home shows courtesy.
4. The text says finishing all the food on your plate is always the polite thing to do everywhere. — *True / False*

5. What does understanding other cultures' customs help us do, according to the text?

- a. Judge people more quickly
- b. Avoid unfair judgement of others
- c. Avoid all travel
- d. Follow only our own norms

6. Which sentence best describes a 'truly polite person' according to the text?

- a. Someone who never leaves their own country
- b. Someone who respects both their own and others' norms
- c. Someone who always shakes hands
- d. Someone who never eats at other people's homes

After you read

- Which custom described in the text was new information for you?
- Do you think it's important to learn local customs before travelling? Why or why not?

What Makes a Good Person?

Before you read

- What three words would you use to describe a person with good values?
- Do you think values like honesty and kindness are the same everywhere, or do they change from place to place?

If you ask ten different people what makes a good person, you will probably get ten different answers. Still, certain values appear again and again in these answers: honesty, kindness, respect, and responsibility. Many people believe that a good person is not only kind to their friends but also fair to strangers.

Honesty is often mentioned first. Telling the truth, even when it is uncomfortable, builds trust between people. A student who admits a mistake honestly, instead of blaming someone else, earns more respect in the long run than one who hides the truth. Integrity — doing the right thing even when no one is watching — is closely connected to honesty.

Kindness and empathy are also seen as essential. A kind person notices when someone is struggling and offers help without expecting anything in return. Empathy allows us to imagine how another person feels, which makes it easier to be patient and understanding, especially with people whose experiences are very different from our own.

Responsibility matters too. Good citizens take responsibility for their actions, both at home and in their community. They understand that their choices — whether it's keeping a promise or recycling their waste — affect other people. Being responsible is not always exciting, but it is one of the clearest signs of maturity.

In the end, there is probably no single answer to what makes a good person. It depends on either the culture you grew up in or the personal experiences that shaped you. What most people can agree on, however, is that values like honesty, kindness, and responsibility make communities stronger — wherever you happen to live.

1. According to the text, which value is mentioned as being closely connected to honesty?
- a. Patience
 - b. Integrity
 - c. Diversity
 - d. Loyalty
2. _____ allows us to imagine how another person feels.
3. What example does the text give of a responsible action?
- a. Winning a competition
 - b. Keeping a promise or recycling waste
 - c. Getting good grades
 - d. Travelling to a new country
4. The text says there is one single, universal answer to what makes a good person. — *True / False*
5. What does a student who honestly admits a mistake earn, according to the text?
- a. Less trust
 - b. More respect in the long run
 - c. A better grade
 - d. No consequences
6. What is the main idea of the last paragraph?
- a. Only one culture has good values
 - b. Values like honesty and kindness make communities stronger everywhere
 - c. Responsibility is not important
 - d. People never agree on values

After you read

- Which value discussed in the text do you think is the most important? Why?
- Can you think of an example from your own life that shows honesty, kindness, or responsibility?